

EYEWITNESS July 15, 1862

The *CSS Arkansas* Runs Through the U.S. Fleet

Armed with ten guns, the *CSS Arkansas*, a largely homemade ironclad, sailed through the large Union fleet anchored above Vicksburg. The determined Confederates let loose a firestorm of shot, crippling the ironclad *USS Carondelet* and damaging a number of other ships. The *Arkansas* then slipped boldly past the Union forces to be greeted ecstatically by the citizens of Vicksburg.

“Aided by the current of the Mississippi, we soon approached the Federal fleet—a forest of masts and smokestacks—ships, rams, iron-clads, and other gun-boats on the left side, and ordinary river steamers and bomb-vessels along the right. To any one having a real ram at command the genius of havoc could not have offered a finer view, the panoramic effect of which was intensified by the city of men spread out with innumerable tents opposite on the right bank. We were not yet in sight of Vicksburg, but in every direction, except astern, our eyes rested on enemies. It seemed at a glance as if a whole navy had come to keep me away from the heroic city—six or seven rams, four or five iron-clads ...

As we advanced, the line of fire seemed to grow into a circle constantly closing ... The shock of missiles striking our sides was literally continuous, and as we were now surrounded without room for anything but pushing ahead, and shrapnel shot were coming on our shield deck, twelve pounds at a time, I went below to see how our Missouri backwoodsmen were handling their 100-pounder Columbiads. At this moment I had the most lively realization of having steamed into a real volcano, the *Arkansas* from its center firing rapidly to every point of the circumference, without the fear of hitting a friend or missing an enemy ... It was a little hot this morning all around; the enemy’s shot frequently found weak places in our armor, and their shrapnel and minié-balls also came through our port-holes. Still, under a temperature of 120, our people kept to their work ...